

THOMAS SZASZ

INTRODUCTION

- Thomas was born on 15 April 1920 and death on 8 September 2012
- He was live in United States in the city of Hungary
- He was in a American psychiatric
- Hi published his book with the name of **THE MYTH OF MENTAL ILLNESS IN 1961.**
- His career was psychiatry but he was anti psychiatry

HIS MAIN EASY:

- Mental illness is a metaphor for the human problems in the living and that mental illness are not illness
- It received much public tea and become an argument “mentally ill”
- It is not making sense to clarify psychological problems as a diseases
- Mental illness has logical or conceptual error
- It is not the conventional research study and not the empirical research papers

Key points of essay

- Most of psychiatric relay on diagnostic statistic manual called DSM
- DSM is a book of mental illness which is consist on various categories of mental illness and consider their symptoms
- but people don't know how DSM was created most of the disorder list in DSM by t
- the process of voting a group of a psychiatric decide rather the selfie disorder should be added in DSM
- No body needed any explanation that voting is social or political process and promoting scientific in nature.

- Loss of mental illness consistency come into the DSM and goes out of the DSM on the basis of a more and like less
- some of these are Unscientific base mental as other set of the construct categories are given by the psychiatrist
- Irony is the that millions of the people labelled with these disorders using these categories they have been hospitalized
- they can find themselves associated taking highly psychiatric drugs sometimes electric shocks mental illness are doesn't exist their manufacturing construct by the psychiatric
- Physical illness is that people have unfortunately mental illness are defined by the sometime that people do
- It is true that a science can study a mental brain tumor because it is a physical disorder but who you are to claim that this person is abnormal
- In some societies when people suffer, they couldn't cope they couldn't be classified as mental I'll

INDIVIDUAL RIGHT:

- Physical illness is discovered in laboratory under microscopes or other scientific process unfortunately mental illness are discovered in a voting psychiatric room
- These medicines are not fully proved
- psychiatric diagnosis is not all about the science and its power
- Now the right of diagnostic hold by psychiatric
- This kind of mental diagnosis is intellectual moral and conceptual fraud and state is a part of it.

THOMAS SZASZ MAIN ARGUMENTS WERE

He argued that for most people categorized as mentally ill, a more appropriate classification of their behavior would be "problems in living" Following is a list of main arguments:

1. The term mental illness is a myth
2. Abolishing insanity defense and involuntary hospitalization
3. Presumption of competence
4. "Patient" as malingerer
5. Separation of psychiatry and the state
6. The right to drugs
7. The right to die

THE TERM MENTAL ILLNESS IS A MYTH:

- so-called mental illnesses cannot legitimately be categorized as disease.
- mental disorders are in the realm of psycho-social-ethical-legal and should not be considered as bodily illnesses or extreme activities
- He also emphasizes the value-lateness of mental disorders, suggesting that the proposition of mental illness is influenced by subjective judgments and societal norms.

ABOLISHING INSANITY DEFENSE AND INVOLUNTARY HOSPITALIZATION:

- involuntary hospitalization and the insanity defense ought to be abolished, exactly as slavery was abolished
- The most important deprivation of human and constitutional rights inflicted upon persons said to be mentally ill is involuntary mental hospitalization
- mental hospitalization is always potentially and often actually a covert form of involuntary mental hospitalization

PRESUMPTION OF COMPETENCE:

- : Just as legal systems work on the presumption that a person is innocent until proven guilty, individuals accused of crimes should not be presumed incompetent simply because a doctor or psychiatrist labels them as such. Mental incompetence should be assessed like any other form of incompetence, i.e., by purely legal and judicial means with the right of representation and appeal by the accused.
- Disproved actions, thoughts and emotions are repressed through pseudo medical interventions
- Suicide, unconventional religious beliefs, unhappiness, anxiety, shyness, smoking and illegal drug use are all considered symptoms and illness that need to be cured

"Patient" as malingerer:

According to Szasz, many people fake their presentation of mental illness, i.e., they are malingerer. They do so for gain, for example, in order to escape a burden like evading the draft, or to gain access to drugs or financial support, or for some other personally meaningful reason. By definition, the malingerer is knowingly deceitful (although malingering itself has also been called a mental illness or disorder). Szasz mentions malingering in many of his works, but it is not what he has in mind to explain many other manifestations of so-called "mental illness". In those cases, so-called "patients" have something personally significant to communicate – their "problems in living" – but unable to express this via conventional means they resort to illnessimitation behavior,

a somatic protolanguage or "body language", which psychiatrists and psychologists have misguidedly interpreted as the signs/symptoms of real illness.

Separation of psychiatry and the state:

Szasz believed that if we accept that "mental illness" is a euphemism for behaviors that are disapproved of, then the state has no right to force psychiatric "treatment" on these individuals. Similarly, the state should not be able to interfere in mental health practices between consenting adults (for example, by legally controlling the supply of psychotropic drugs or psychiatric medication). The medicalization of government produces a "therapeutic state", designating someone as, for example, "insane" or as a "drug addict". **The right to drugs:**

Drug addiction is not a "disease" to be cured through legal drugs but a social habit. Szasz also argues in favor of a free market for drugs. He criticized the war on drugs, arguing that using drugs is in fact a victimless crime.

Szasz also drew analogies between the persecution of the drug-using minority and the persecution of Jewish and homosexual minorities.

The Nazis spoke of having a "Jewish problem". We now speak of having a drug-abuse problem. Actually, "Jewish problem" was the name the Germans gave to their persecution of the Jews; "drug-abuse problem" is the name we give to the persecution of people who use certain drugs.

The right to die:

Szasz argue that individuals should be able to chosen when to die without interference from medicine and the state, as just they are able to choose when to conceive without outside interference. He considered suicide to be among the most fundamental rights, but he opposed state sanctioned euthanasia.

Criticism on THOMAS SZAZ's perspective

Thomas Szasz, a prominent figure in the field of psychiatry and psychology, is known for his critique of traditional psychiatric concepts and practices. From an existential perspective, there are several criticisms of Szasz's work:

Rejection of Mental Illness: Szasz famously argued that mental illness is a myth and that what we call mental illness is better understood as problems in living or moral conflicts. However, existentialists might argue that while social and cultural factors influence psychological distress, there can still be genuine existential suffering and mental anguish that warrant attention and care.

Stigmatization of Mental Health Treatment: Szasz's views on mental illness and involuntary psychiatric treatment can contribute to stigmatization by suggesting that seeking help for mental health issues is a sign of weakness or moral failing rather than a legitimate need for support and treatment.

Neglect of Existential Dimensions: Critics argue that Szasz's focus on individual autonomy and personal responsibility overlooks the existential dimensions of suffering, such as feelings of meaninglessness, existential anxiety, and the search for authenticity, which are central concerns in existential therapy and philosophy.

Ethical Concerns: From an existential perspective, there are ethical concerns about Szasz's absolute stance against involuntary psychiatric interventions, as it may neglect situations where individuals are in acute distress and unable to make rational decisions about their own care.

Societal Context: Existentialists emphasize the importance of understanding individual struggles within the broader societal context. While Szasz acknowledged societal influences on mental health, his emphasis on individual freedom and responsibility could be seen as neglecting systemic issues that contribute to psychological distress, such as poverty, discrimination, and social inequality.

In summary, while Thomas Szasz's critiques of traditional psychiatry have sparked important debates about the nature of mental illness and the role of psychiatric interventions, his perspective has been subject to criticism from an existential viewpoint for its potential to overlook existential dimensions of suffering and its implications for understanding and addressing mental health challenges.

